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The Class Dynamics of Ocean Grabbing: Who Are the 'Fisher Peoples'?

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ABSTRACT

Amidst processes of (uneven) dispossession and displacement of coastal populations—often termed 'ocean grabbing'—scholar-activists, NGOs and the leadership of different social movements invoke, so-called, 'fisher people' as the political subjects of resistance. These 'fisher people' are often cast as capital's other as part of a normative and moral critique of ocean grabbing and purportedly the agents of change towards 'blue justice'. Arguing for the importance of analytically differentiating within and between both classes of capital *and* classes of labour, this intervention draws on a seemingly clear-cut case of violent ocean grabbing in Southern Myanmar to question prevalent assumptions around undifferentiated 'fisher peoples'. The intervention argues that the literatures on ocean grabbing and blue (in)justice could usefully draw from the conceptual tools of Marxist agrarian political economy to better analyse concrete social relations of production and reproduction.

1 | Introduction

> In some places still, an effective community, of a local kind, can survive in older terms, where small freeholders, tenants and craftsmen and labourers can succeed in being neighbours first and social classes only second. This must never be idealized, for at the points of decision, now as then, the class realities usually show through.
>
> (Williams 1973, 106)

In contrast to its agrarian counterpart, the fisheries literature—particularly that looking at so-called small-scale fisheries[1]—is notable for its general paucity on the question of class. Over a decade ago, the introductory paper to a special issue on the political economy and ecology of capture fisheries in this *Journal* noted how debates across the few social science journals devoted to marine issues 'are framed primarily through a policy-orientated lens, where (often undifferentiated) fishing "communities" are frequently cited as subjects in and for the better "management" of resources' (Campling et al. 2012, 178).

Since that intervention, what might be called a critical marine social science literature around small-scale fisheries has emerged. This includes a small literature around the idea of 'ocean grabbing' (inspired by the World Forum of Fisher Peoples' invocation of the term[2]) emerging from 2015 onwards (see Bennett et al. 2015), and more recently, those associated with the Too Big To Ignore network have launched a research agenda around the idea of 'blue justice'. This furthermore comes in the slipstream of calls within one of the above-mentioned journals for a reinvigorated research agenda that sees 'fisheries as social struggle' (Bavinck et al. 2018, 46).

Unfortunately, the subjects envisioned in this critical marine social science remain undifferentiated fishers, fisher peoples and/or fisher communities. This entails an analytically

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problematic deduction of (1) homogenous small-scale fisher/coastal communities as neat and bounded units of analysis that are (2) presumed to be impacted homogeneously by processes of dispossession and displacement and therefore (3) to constitute a priori a united political subject in resistance to such processes. As explained in perhaps the most ambitious intervention within the blue justice literature yet for how it seeks to 'reveal the blue layers of environmental justice', 'the main social actors are *small-scale fisher people* resisting continuous growth and destructive expansion' (Ertör 2023, 1159, emphasis added). Similarly, a review of blue justice literature clarifies that authors within this tradition are concerned with 'equity and justice for *coastal people*', and the literature seeks to 'position blue justice as a counter-narrative to the blue economy' (Blythe et al. 2023, 3; 2, emphasis added). As such, by way of the environmental justice literature, these authors are explicitly engaged in the age-old exercise of 'fighting against "phrases"' (Marx and Engels 1998, 36) counterposing their narrative of 'blue justice' against the narrative of 'blue economy' (see e.g., Bennett et al. 2021).[3] The aim seems to be to take the literature in a more normative and explicitly moralizing direction in order to deliver blue justice, involving 'the recognition, meaningful involvement and fair treatment of all coastal people with respect to how ocean and coastal resources are accessed, used, managed, and enjoyed' (Blythe et al. 2023, 3).

In contrast to such moralizing tendencies, this intervention argues that the critical marine social science literature's laudable aim of grappling with dispossession, displacement and possible resistance thereto can gain much from debates within agrarian political economy. This concerns especially Marxist agrarian political economy's efforts to challenge the idea of homogenous peasantries by revealing how, as Raymond Williams puts it in the opening quote, class realities show through. Once uncovered, I argue, this class reality poses a challenge to the above critical marine social scientists' assumptions about the political subjects—the fisher peoples—that are expected to deliver and benefit from blue justice. I build up the argument with reference to a vignette from a fishing village in Southeastern Myanmar: how a seemingly clear-cut case of ocean grabbing and blue injustice (indeed, the case is in the environmental justice atlas and included in Ertör's 120 'fisher folk conflicts') is complicated by actual class-dynamics on the ground. Mobilising a class-relational approach that distinguishes both within and between class*es* of capital and labour, I elucidate the significant degree of differentiation along lines of class, gender and generation within the village. Such differentiation heavily shapes how people can respond in moments of 'grabs' or 'injustice', and these differences therefore matter (or should matter) for the question of resistance that critical marine social science is interested in contributing to.

2 | Classes of Capital and Labour

As noted, Ertör (2023) is perhaps the most ambitious intervention amongst the 'blue justice'-tendency for how it proposes an actual framework based on a deeper engagement with the environmental justice literature. Ertör builds up a framework for analysis of what she calls 'fisher folk conflicts' through three dimensions: material and biophysical threats (through 'industrial capture fisheries and intensive marine aquaculture', 1165); struggles against ocean grabbing and displacement; and finally, the struggle for autonomy and sovereignty. It is particularly notable for its recognition of how 'the marine social science literature lacks detailed class analysis in fisheries' (Ertör 2023, 1161). As she goes on to note, class dynamics have been 'discussed in much further detail in research focusing on peasants' (ibid). Rather than going towards Marxist agrarian political economy to rectify this, however, she turns towards agrarian populist authors (e.g., Rosset) to counterpose 'small-scale fisher communities ... against their capitalist and industrialized counterparts as well as against the attempts by other coastal industries grabbing their resources' (ibid, 1162). Similar to the agrarian populist tradition then, Ertör's intervention ends up depicting fisher 'communities'/'peoples' as somehow constituting 'capital's other' (Bernstein 2014, 1041).

In contemporary world-encompassing capitalism,[4] I think a more useful point of departure to deal with the lacking detailed class analysis in fisheries rightfully flagged by Ertör are the conceptual tools and lines of questioning within Marxist agrarian political economy concerning the social relations of production and reproduction. These have usefully been distilled in Bernstein's 'Marxian *haiku*'[5]: who owns what, who does what, who gets what and what do they do with it?[6] Carefully grappling with these questions allows us to be empirically attuned to capitalist social relations in their phenomenal and varied forms, i.e., as 'accessible to, hence can be "known" by observation and experience' (Bernstein 1988, 261) *within* 'small-scale fisher communities'. To be sure, this is empirically challenging,[7] but all the more both analytically and politically interesting, precisely because such social formations bring out the 'endless variations and gradations in appearance' of the essential relation between capital and wage-labour under capitalism (Marx 1991, 927). With inspiration from Ertör's move of looking towards the broad field of agrarian studies for tools to grapple with class in fisheries, I look towards a different lineage, namely, the explicitly Marxist agrarian political economy of, especially, Henry Bernstein and his notions of classes of capital and classes of labour.

Bernstein (2010, 112) introduces classes of capital as a means to move towards a greater level of conceptual specificity from Capital (upper case C) in general to distinguish between 'interests and strategies of capital in particular activities and sectors and on scales from local to regional, national to transnational'. The last point about scale is particularly significant here in that it emphasizes that capital as a social relation is at play 'from households and "small businesses", including petty commodity producers in farming, to global corporations' (ibid; see also Baglioni 2015 and Campling 2021). This emphasizes the great variety of phenomenal forms that the essential category of 'the capitalist' can take, but following Pattenden (2016) what unites the capitalist class is that they are net buyers of labour power (see also Patnaik 1976). The point about class*es* of capital then is to emphasize Bernstein's point about scale and variation. While classes of capital are net buyers of labour power, this spans those who are surplus producers and who exclusively rely on hired labour to so-called petty capitalists that rely on both family labour and hired labour and do not consistently produce a surplus. This difference has implications

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for how people can respond in moments of conflict around property (i.e., 'grabs'). Surplus producers are more likely to diversify their accumulation strategies (e.g., into other commodities and sectors) giving them some safety. The choices for petty capitalists are more limited, and they may end up being relegated to classes of labour having to sell their labour power, or to sell more of it.

Similarly, the notion of classes of labour provides a prism through which to grapple with the endless variations faced by contemporary labouring classes in the countryside, wherein simple reproduction entails navigating 'different sites of the social division of labour: urban and rural, agricultural and non-agricultural, wage-employment and marginal self-employment' (Bernstein 2010, 111). I include within classes of labour petty commodity producers[8] who engage in 'marginal self-employment' through their combination of capital and labour within their household, but who also have to sell their labour power to survive and are hence facing what Bernstein (2010) calls the 'simple reproduction squeeze' (see also Pattenden 2024). Generally, for classes of labour, the class-relation involves the universal predicament of having to sell your labour power to survive. However, this predicament is 'universal, but not [the] exclusive' challenge facing classes of labour as selling one's labour power—or selling enough of it—is further complicated by other social divisions, which as we will see below include those along lines of gender and generation (ibid, 115). Such social divisions may be actively seized upon and contributed to through capitalist strategies of various wage levels according to gender and generation (Pattenden 2016). In the class-relational approach adopted here then, class is seen as a plural category, which is 'inflected by other forms of differences and antagonism that are partially, but never entirely discrete from it' (ibid, 31). Consequently, while members of the classes of labour in situations of conflict obviously have very different strategies of response available to them from the classes of capital, important differentiations *within* labouring classes also mean that any given labourer will have very different objective opportunities.

As the next section seeks to argue, these analytical categories developed in Marxist agrarian political economy can usefully be applied to those instances of dispossession and displacement (injustices, to be sure) with important implications for questions of resistance that the ocean grabbing and blue (in)justice literature is interested in highlighting. As phenomenal categories intended to grapple with variation, they can helpfully be adopted to examine how the essential relation between capital and wage-labour expresses itself also in 'small-scale fisher communities'.[9]

3 | Classes of Capital and Labour in a Fishing Village in Southeastern Myanmar

As an illustrative case to support the argument, this section brings a vignette from a village[10] in the Tanintharyi Division of Southeastern Myanmar. The fisheries production system here was significantly transformed by one of the instances of, so-called, 'fisher folk conflicts' examined by Ertör (2023), namely, the building of several offshore gas pipelines from the early 1990s that hit the shoreline just south of the village. This initially led to violent displacement of populations in the area with many fleeing from the village to end up as internally displaced people. The impacts on the fisheries production system were then exacerbated by the increasing intrusion of capital-intensive fisheries from the 2000s onwards.[11] As such, the case has both of the first two threat-dimensions in Ertör's framework. However, mobilising the noted class-relational approach also shows how people in this fishing village have markedly different strategies available to them depending on their position within classes of capital or classes of labour. Consequently, the below focuses on changes in this local labour control regime (Pattenden 2018) through the decisions of various classes of capital responding to (1) the intrusion of more capital-intensive fisheries further in-shore and (2) dwindling of appropriate labour supply. Their response to these two points has led to the class, gender and generational divisions elucidated in Table 1. While being spatially squeezed by larger scales of fishing capital from outside the village, the households within classes of capital can accumulate (to differing degrees) and are transitioning out of fisheries by buying land for rubber production. These households make up less than 10% of the village.[12] By contrast, those within classes of labour are struggling to reproduce themselves ('just surviving'). Through a strategy of labour fragmentation by classes of capital, important distinctions within the group of households categorised as classes of labour also exist between men and women and with women in certain age groups especially immiserated through their exclusion from a contract system (see Table 1).

Since the early 2000s, the intrusion of more capital-intensive fisheries (in the form of larger vessels from both Thailand and Myanmar's own domestic offshore fleet) into inshore areas has become a regular factor to reckon with for all boat owners in the village. By law, the larger vessels are not supposed to move within the 10 nautical miles zones, yet up and down the coast of Tanintharyi such intrusions are a regular sight. This intrusion has created havoc in the village's production system. Their rotational method of fishing, progressively migrating through 10 nautical miles, is based on the use of bagnets that are fastened with rocks on the seabed—venturing out twice per 24 h in motorized boats to change the nets. However, with the intrusion of the larger vessels, the boat owners' fishing nets are destroyed if these larger vessels come across their nets. Consequently, boat owners implore their workers, not to go beyond six nautical miles, which has become the new typical limit for how close the large-scale vessels intrude. The destruction and loss of boat owners' equipment can lead to a debt spiral that is difficult to get out of—especially consequential for petty capitalist and PCP-households. As a result of this smaller catchment area available to them along with an intensification of their own fishing efforts following from the application of improved means of labour (nets, engines, etc.), their catches are far below what they were historically. As one of the boat owners categorised as petty capitalist described, 'With lots of cows on a smaller pasture then how can you get enough for your stomach?'[13]

Concomitantly with this physical reduction of space and the subsequent necessity of transforming the fishing practice, there was a disruption in the labour supply in the village. In the 1980s, prior to the pipelines and the associated road network being built, the villagers interviewed that lived there at the time,

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TABLE 1 | Different roles in the fisheries production system depending on class, gender and generation.

Household type	Basis of simple and expanded reproduction	Fishing gear and other means of production	Role in production	Costs and terms of trade
Classes of capital (approximately 25 out of 280 HH)	Capitalists	More than 4 boats[a]	Little or no direct involvement in labour process	Bypass merchants through kinship networks
		Own more than 10 acres of land	Hiring in of labourers	Usually debt-free
			Some also in merchant-role to other boat owners	Three male workers and 1–2 contracted women per boat (see 'wage-labour')
	Petty capitalists	Between 2 and 4 boats	Owners engaged in labour process on par with their labourers	Often in debt to merchants leading to dependence on them and hence lower price for their catch
		Some have land plots	Hiring in of labourers	Three male workers and 1–2 contracted women per boat
Classes of labour (approximately 255 out of 280 HH, of which ca. 15 PCP)	Petty commodity production[b]	One boat	Family labour and occassional selling of their labour power	Often in debt to merchants leading to dependence on them and hence lower price for their catch
		No land		
	Wage-labour	**Gender**	**Terms of labour**	**Wages**
		Male—harvest activities in groups of three pr. boat	From the age of 16, all males are contracted.	Monthly wage of 50–70 USD depending on level of seniority on the boat
			Meals provided by boat owners	Often in debt to boat owners
		Female—preharvest and postharvest activities (preparing food, sorting and processing the catch)	Contracted between ages 16 and 30	Monthly wage of 28–30 USD
			Meals provided by boat owners	Often in debt to boat owners
			No contracts under 16, when pregnant or after the age of 30	Daily piecemeal rates based on number of containers of shrimp gathered from the catch. On a monthly basis wages vary from 5 to 9 USD.
			No meals provided	Often in debt to boat owners

[a]One boat costs 1190 USD with usually 25 nets per boat at 70 USD each. All figures in table converted from MMK with 1 USD = 2098 MMK;
[b]I am here not making a general point about PCP as always being classes of labour. Following the approach argued for generally in the paper appreciating the 'concrete diversity of PCP' (Bernstein 1988, 262), then whether PCP is categorised as classes of capital or labour in a given circumstance is an empirical question.

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described the village as being closed off and more tightknit than it was at the time of fieldwork. With first the pipeline and later the road network, however, major changes took place through what interviewees described as an opening up of the village.

The building of the first pipeline relied on slave labour from the surrounding villages, as well as from farther North in Mon State. With the pipeline's interruption of the fisheries production system and their lives more generally, many of the villagers fled the village to pursue their luck in Thailand—although often ending up in refugee camps along the border. Simultaneously with this exodus, the building of a road around 1995/1996 linked the village to the regional capital. The road was initially built to facilitate the movement of one of the gas companies' employees (Total) to guard the pipeline—guards which remained at the site of landfall just South of the village when fieldwork was conducted. With the road came also new flows of labour, commodities and merchant's capital. While this new source of migrant labour intuitively perhaps should have been to the immediate benefit of village (petty) capitalists, they deplored that many of these incoming migrants had never even seen the sea, let alone had any fishing experience.

As a result, classes of capital from the late 1990s faced a shortage of what they called 'smart workers' and steep competition amongst each other to attract the ones that were available. In an attempt to attract the best workers, they began giving advance payments in order to try and secure their labour for the entire fishing season.[14] However, to their dismay, as this system became generalized as a prerequisite for attaining any labour at all, some of the labourers with looser ties to the village would take the money and simply leave. In a remarkable display of class agency, the boat owners responded in an organized way by initiating a new contract system for wage employment, protecting themselves against footloose migrant labour as well as formalizing a tiered system of exploitation of labour according to gender and age.

These contracts stipulate terms of employment as well as the listing of four witnesses within the village that have to sign the contract as an insurance policy toward the boat owners. If the worker flees prior to the end of the season, the witnesses are liable for the advance payment that the boat owner has given out. The contracts formalize the gendered system of labour, whereby men go out to sea and women do the inland preharvest and postharvest activities. Furthermore, the system relies on a tiered remuneration, with females of certain ages or situations especially immiserated by the boat owners. The contract system had therefore formalised a labour regime based around the two overall classes of capital and labour—each of which is internally differentiated.

As Table 1 above suggests, the *classes of capital* span those able to accumulate with little or no involvement in the labour process (a 'director general'-role as one of these put it) to smaller scales of capital where the owners themselves are engaged in the labour process. I characterise these as petty capitalists, distinguishing them from the 'director generals', because of their own involvement in the labour process and their slower rate of accumulation—partly resulting from their relations of debt to merchants personified either by the capitalists in the village or outside merchants impinging on their profit. Regardless of how much or how fast they were able to accumulate, what united these (petty) capitalists is that whatever profits they were making from fisheries, they were using to actively escape from the sector. This happened through a 'shift to a new realm of production' by buying up land for rubber (or in a few cases beetlenut) production (Campling et al. 2016, 1751). Simultaneously, these also unevenly invested in the education of their children, i.e., a form of social reproduction entailing the 'securing of the conditions of life and of future production from what is produced or earned now' (Bernstein 2010, 128). Aside from the fundamental class-relation, then, these two strategies available to households within classes of capital objectively clearly distinguish them from the classes of labour in the village for whom such strategies are not possible.

Classes of labour span petty commodity producers that own a single boat and engage in production based on family labour alone (hence combining capital and labour within the household) but may also have to sell part of their labour power, to the broader group of wage-labourers who own nothing but their labour power and are intricately fragmented around gender and generation. Most within the group of petty commodity producers were facing the simple reproduction squeeze, often mired in debt to the classes of capital within the village or merchants outside of it and dependent on remittances from migrant labour within the household to stay afloat—dynamics so characteristic of the simple reproduction squeeze (Bernstein 2010). For the wage-labourers writ large, Table 1 outlines the gendered and generational divides within this majority of people in the village. Where the men go out to sea and perform all labour related to harvesting, the women perform all preharvest and postharvest activities—with a significant divergence of the wage remuneration for these purportedly male and female tasks. For women, the degree of participation and the remuneration from this work furthermore varies through the course of their lives. Contracted work and monthly wages only go to women between the ages of 16 and 30 who are not pregnant. Those not falling within this category are instead on a daily basis remunerated through piece-rated wage-labour according to the number of containers of shrimp they are able to sort from a particular catch. They continuously have to seek out such work on a daily basis, which is not always possible to attain. This results in around 1/6th the wage of contracted women and 1/10th of contracted men. Across the board of classes of labour, debt-relations typically existed with the boat-owners they worked for.

There is of course much more to say about this labour regime and the classes of capital and labour that are bound together through it than this short vignette allows for, but hopefully what I have sketched above gives enough basis to say that in this, so-called, 'fisher folk conflict', it is difficult to identify a homogenous 'fisher community'. Rather, what we find is social diversity, difference and conflict, where processes of dispossession and displacement shape and are shaped by processes of class differentiation and exploitation. Furthermore, this particular labour regime also belies the notion, 'often unspoken, though sometimes stated explicitly', in existing literature that 'small-scale fisheries are relatively egalitarian in nature' and therefore in and of itself worth saving (mirroring the general 'small is beautiful'-sentiment in much environmental justice literature) (Belton et al. 2019, 205).

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4 | Reflections on 'Struggle' and Research

> We definitely fight for the survival of small-scale fishing, but not the survival as it is now. The survival of a new model ... There is not only one struggle against the bad industrial guys who overfish, but there is also an inside struggle within the small-scale sector, of how do we support workers, racialized people, women and also LGBTQ-people ... to have rights in this small-scale fishing sector? ... It's a double struggle between maintaining a sector and changing the sector from the inside.
>
> (Thibault Josse, quoted in TNI Podcast, 2022)

Internal tensions and challenges and the far from egalitarian nature of small-scale fisheries are well-known by movement cadres doing the mobilising and organising on the ground. As expressed here by an organiser in the French group Pleine Mer, the class reality and its articulation with other divisions around gender and race is apparent and should not be shied away from. Rather, as he neatly puts it, these need to be dealt with as part of a 'double-struggle'. Instead of engaging in a fisher peoples' 'essentialism',[15] as seems to increasingly be the case in critical marine social science research, a contribution for research to that double-struggle would be to bring those tensions and challenges to the fore. As Josse went on to note in the same conversation on the difficulties around mobilising and organising within the small-scale fisheries sector in France and internationally, while 'obviously you want to put everyone under the same banner, so you want to be united, together', it is ultimately necessary to 'bring a little bit more complexity in the narrative' (ibid). This alludes to a point also raised in analogous debates within agrarian studies on progressive politics and populism that any and all strategic essentialising by movements (and researchers!)—such as invocations of 'fisher peoples'—should be interrogated for 'which interests are swept under the carpet' in the process (Lerche 2021, 1387; and for different positions on the promise and pitfalls of multiclass agrarian movements see the special issue of this *Journal* edited by Pattenden 2023).

It is exactly that complexity that the tools of Marxist agrarian political economy—part discussed and mobilised here—are well-poised to contribute to the existing bodies of research on ocean grabbing and blue (in)justice. Here, in conclusion, I therefore, yet again, invoke Bernstein (2006, 457) that this somewhat critical intervention is meant in the most constructive sense to 'contribute to a dispassionate and realistic analysis of the social conditions of classes of labour in global capitalism, and the challenges their diverse forms of fragmentation present to those whose political sympathies are with the exploited and oppressed'. Connected and on a more methodological note, a more sober, careful analysis of social relations may encourage those working in the literature to move beyond a fascination with the spectacular. Momentarily striking occurrences of dispossession and displacement must be grasped in relation to the more mundane, but no less crucial, processes of class differentiation. This differentiation plays out not just in relation to some abstracted Capital, but by paying close attention to changes in capitalist social relations across scales—herein, in those otherwise idealised 'fishing communities'. As noted in a review of coastal transitions in Southeast Asia, 'everyday processes of differentiation ... are a key element of coastal transitions but are often overlooked in accounts that privilege dramatic or highly visible large-scale events' (Fabinyi et al. 2022, 191).[16] This has implications for the *how* of doing research on ocean grabbing and blue (in)justice in that the object of research cannot just be the particular instance or moment of grabbing viewed in isolation, but should encompass both what came before and after that moment.[17] In addition to such historicising, the particular places of dispossession and displacement need to be analysed within the broader landscapes in which such processes are unfolding (Barbesgaard 2019a, 2019b). For sure, all of this might involve asking tricky and awkward questions (not to mention the answers found) that put researchers at odds with populist currents within social movements (and research) for challenging existing 'narratives' they put forward, but what is our role if not to ask (and answer) such tricky and awkward questions?[18]

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In the spirit of what Jun Borras (2023) has called 'half-full criticism', an earlier version of this paper was presented to the World Forum of Fisher Peoples-organised webinar 'Re-imagining Fisher Peoples' Identities: Political challenges and path forward' in October 2024. I think it is also fitting here to acknowledge how much I have learned analytically and politically from engaging with leaders from WFFP through the 2010s, especially Naseegh Jaffer, Herman Kumara and the late Muhammad Ali Shah. Furthermore, I would like to thank all TNI-colleagues for ongoing discussions on these issues (and much else). Finally, many thanks to the two journal reviewers that provided very helpful suggestions. Any errors of course are my own.

Data Availability Statement

Research data are not shared.

Endnotes

[1] The slippery question of scale in marine fisheries is beyond the scope of this paper, but it is worth noting that there is no agreed global definition of 'small scale' or 'artisanal' fisheries.

[2] In the form of a 'primer', *The Global Ocean Grab*, published with a number of allies in 2014 just prior to their 6th General Assembly, see:https://worldfishers.org/2014/08/21/new-report-ocean-grabbing/.

[3] For discussion of how the blue economy—in contrast to proponents' claims—constitutes little more than a discursive smokescreen for the expansion of new and old ocean industries, see Brent et al. (2020). Conversely, for critique of how much of the literature around various 'blues' has an 'overdetermining analytical focus on blue growth semantics and institutional politics', see Mallin & Barbesgaard (2020, 122).

[4] Here understood as entailing 'generalized commodity production founded upon the contradictory relation between capital and wage-labour' (Gibbon and Neocosmos 1986, 156). Importantly, as should hopefully become clear '[t]his is not a view of capitalism as everywhere and always identical ... but the opposite' instead arguing in favour of a particular method for grappling with 'the immensely contradictory, complex, diverse and fluctuating phenomenal realities and experiences of capitalist society' (Bernstein 1986, 24; see also Bernstein 1988).

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[5] As Watts (2012, 200) sums it up in his review of Bernstein (2010).

[6] Ertör's framework and the ocean grabbing and blue justice literatures writ large tend to foreground the first question around property relations to the neglect of the remaining three questions. Despite early criticisms along these lines (see Li 2011, 2014 and Oya 2013), this is a point that might also be levelled against the continuing focus on land grabbing in 'critical agrarian studies' more generally over the past decade or so.

[7] In an interview by Subir Sinha, Bernstein (2019) himself notes that mobilising these categories are 'extremely empirically challenging' and for a refreshing transparence on such difficulties in the field, see the methods section in Pattenden (2024).

[8] Understood following Gibbon and Neocosmos (1985, 170) as 'a phenomenal category of commodity producers who possess the means of production necessary to produce commodities, and who engage in production on the basis of unpaid household labour alone'. For further discussion, see also Bernstein (1986, 1988) and for its enduring analytical significance, see Harriss-White (2023).

[9] For further discussion of the distinction between essential and phenomenal and the underlying method of analysis, see Gibbon and Neocosmos (1985); Bernstein (1986, 1988) and, more recently, Campling et al. (2016); Capps (2016).

[10] The village consisted of approximately 280 households. Though providing an accurate picture of class dynamics at the time, the following is based on rounds of fieldwork (totaling around 7 months) conducted in the village between October 2016 and January 2018 (this included data-gathering in two other villages, though that data is not drawn upon here). Hence, data are from before the military coup in February 2021. Consequently, this vignette and the data are used exclusively for illustrative purposes in the context of the argument pursued here and do not mean to convey anything about the current moment in Myanmar. For analysis and reflections on the current postcoup context, see e.g., Borras et al. (2022) and Aung (2025)

[11] As examined elsewhere (Barbesgaard 2019a; Barbesgaard 2019b), the several rounds of building of the pipelines were a significant intervention into the landscape facilitating new geographies of accumulation and state power and constituted by the Myanmar military regime wrestling control of the land and sea-territory away from various Ethnic Armed Organisations.

[12] Pattenden's (2024) work in Uganda and Pattenden and Wastuti's (2023) in Indonesia show similarly high proportions of classes of labour.

[13] Interview 22, 04.11.2017.

[14] For a broader discussion on the role of debt in modern forms in so-called 'neo-bondage', see Breman et al. (2009).

[15] Mirroring the current of 'peasant essentialism' found in agrarian studies (Bernstein and Byres 2001, 6–8)

[16] In this regard, the small but hopefully growing literature interrogating coastal transitions and questions of labour in fisheries is promising (see Belton et al. 2019; Fabinyi et al. 2019; Rahmat and Neilson 2023).

[17] An approach that would also be consistent with the basic principles outlined by Oya (2004, 289) for 'sensible treatment of the agrarian question and processes of rural class formation'.

[18] For reflections on navigating such a role, see the concluding discussion in Borras (2023).

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